

Ethics with a firewall

Kantianism, but make it group-chat proof

HCMUS-FITUS

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If you only remember one thing: *make rules you'd accept for everyone.*



Immanuel Kant

Kant's filter

Kant is not asking, “Did it work?”

He is asking:

Could everyone do this?

Did I treat people as people — not tools?

Was my intention clean?

That is basically ethics with no “but bro, hear me out...” loophole.

A “firewall” blocks actions that fail these checks.

The audit function

```
KantAudit(action):  
    rule = "What if everyone did this?"  
    respect = "Am I using someone only as a tool?"  
    motive = "Am I doing the right thing for the right reason?"  
  
    if rule fails or respect fails:  
        return "Not Kant-approved"  
    else:  
        return "Morally safer"
```

Computer science stays — just enough to keep the logic sharp.

3 a.m., deadline in 6 hours

You ask ChatGPT to write most of your essay.

You change a few words.

You submit it under your own name.

Class vote: survival skill or academic catfish?

Kant's verdict: not the vibe

Universal rule test

If everyone submits AI-written work as their own, grades stop meaning “student ability.”

Respect test

The teacher and classmates are treated as obstacles to trick, not rational people to be honest with.

Better move

Use AI for outline, examples, grammar checks — then write and cite honestly.

The viral “artist scandal” clip

A Vietnamese celebrity is trending because people claim a clip shows drug use. No official conclusion yet, but the internet is already editing, reposting, joking.

Do you share it before checking?

- A. “Everyone is posting anyway.”
- B. “I wait.”
- C. “I post, but with ‘allegedly’ so I’m safe.”

Kant's verdict: clout is not a moral excuse

Universal rule test

If everyone spreads unverified accusations, reputation becomes a public punching bag.

Respect test

The person becomes content for entertainment — a means to likes, laughs, and reactions.

Kant-friendly move

Discuss the ethical issue: fame, responsibility, drug culture, legal process.

Do not turn an unverified person into a meme target.

The “mark me present” favor

Many students do not study PE but want the class monitor to take attendance for them. One individual is “fine”... but what if half the class is absent?

Do you ask the monitor to mark you present?

Kant's verdict: honesty isn't optional

Universal rule test

If everyone gets marked present while absent, attendance stops meaning “who actually participated.”

Fairness collapses (and the rule becomes pointless).

Respect test

The teacher and classmates get treated like a system to exploit, not people to be honest with.

Motive check

“Avoid consequences” is not a clean motive in Kant's view.

Kant-friendly move

Be honest about absence, accept the outcome, and fix the real issue (schedule, health, workload) without cheating the rule.

Quick audit round

Raise your hand if Kant would approve:

1. Using AI to brainstorm, then writing honestly
2. Screenshotting a private chat for drama
3. Refusing to ship unsafe code
4. Posting a scandal clip “because it is already viral”

Kant is strict, but he is consistent. Annoyingly consistent.

Takeaway

Kantianism is not about being perfect.

It is about installing one habit:

**Can this become a rule for everyone?
Am I respecting people, or using them?**

Final message: If you wouldn't want it as a rule, don't hit "send".